

Module 6: Refugees, Asylum, and Forced Displacement

Signature Learning Experience

Purpose

Students evaluate whether asylum systems actually deliver the protection they promise. Using real performance evidence — recognition rates, backlogs, appeal outcomes, reception conditions — each student writes a policy critique of one asylum system, learning to judge institutions by results rather than intentions.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Define refugee and asylum categories precisely as the law uses them (UG 1)
- Describe how the chosen protection system works on paper (UG 2)
- Compare migrant categories and their different entitlements within the system (UG 3)

Graduate extension

Graduate students make it comparative — two systems, standardized metrics, honest treatment of data comparability problems — and close with evidence-based reform recommendations (Grad 1–2).

Assignment steps

1. Choose one national asylum system (US, UK, Germany, Kenya, Colombia, Australia...) with instructor approval to ensure spread across the class.
2. Map the system as designed: application path, decision stages, appeal rights, reception conditions, and the legal standards applied.
3. Gather performance evidence: recognition rates by nationality, median processing times, backlog size, appeal reversal rates, detention use (EUAA, UNHCR, TRAC, national statistics).
4. Identify the two or three largest gaps between design and performance, and diagnose why each exists (resourcing, politics, legal design, geography).
5. Write the critique: system description, performance evidence, gap diagnosis, and one realistic improvement — with the tradeoffs of your proposal stated honestly.
6. Exchange drafts with a classmate who studied a different system; add a paragraph comparing what each system does better.

Deliverables & format

- Policy critique, 1,800–2,200 words (graduate: comparative version, 3,000+, two systems)
- One table or chart of system performance metrics with sources
- Comparison paragraph from the draft exchange

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Accuracy of the legal and procedural description 25%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: accuracy of the legal and procedural description is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: accuracy of the legal and procedural description is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: accuracy of the legal and procedural description is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: accuracy of the legal and procedural description is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Quality of performance evidence 30%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: quality of performance evidence is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: quality of performance evidence is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: quality of performance evidence is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: quality of performance evidence is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Diagnosis — explaining why gaps exist, not just that they do 25%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: diagnosis — explaining why gaps exist, not just that they do goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: diagnosis — explaining why gaps exist, not just that they do is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: diagnosis — explaining why gaps exist, not just that they do is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: diagnosis — explaining why gaps exist, not just that they do is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Realism of the proposed improvement, tradeoffs included 20%	Design judgment is excellent: realism of the proposed improvement, tradeoffs included is fully addressed — costs, constraints, politics, and failure modes are named honestly and the proposal remains workable anyway.	Design judgment is good: realism of the proposed improvement, tradeoffs included is addressed for the major factors, with minor blind spots that would not sink the proposal.	Design judgment is limited: realism of the proposed improvement, tradeoffs included is addressed superficially — key constraints or failure modes are ignored, making the proposal fragile.	Design judgment is missing: realism of the proposed improvement, tradeoffs included is not addressed; the proposal ignores obvious constraints and would not survive contact with reality.